Once the political canvas was thus reframed, the BJP's turning point came with the 2008 Hindu–Muslim riots.[159] As one senior editor told me, 'Everything changed in 2008 when anti-Muslim riots happened in Udalguri and Nalbari [districts]. This was the first time that Hindu Bengalis and Nepalis fully aligned with Bodos against Muslims. In Assam, communal violence in the past had mostly been about Bengalis versus non-Bengalis. It was not because of religion earlier.'[160]

While it is true that Assam had seen the Nellie massacre in 1983, where over 2,000 Muslim migrants had been killed in horrific election-linked violence over illegal migration in Nagaon, communal tensions were never the default template for the state's politics. 'In 2008, Bengali Muslims were isolated,' the editor told me. 'Bengali Hindus started getting together and sided against them. This is why Congress leaders in Barak Valley are so quiet about these issues even now. Many Bengali Hindus now see themselves as threatened by Bengali-speaking Muslims [not Assamese Muslims who are seen as sons of the soil] and have bought into the idea of resistance to Muslim outsiders. This helps explain why the BJP was voted in.'[161]

The BJP initially supported the Assam movement and then aligned with the political heir to the movement, the AGP, in 2006. Eventually, as the regional party started declining, the BJP captured its political mantle and drew in large numbers of its leadership as well. 'The detection, deletion and deportation of illegal foreigners were the main electoral plank of the AGP which has been, in the last two decades, gradually hijacked by the electoral agenda of the BJP.'[162] While some critics have questioned the veracity of the infiltration narrative and whether Muslim migration was as widespread as those who opposed it argued,[163] it became the leitmotif of the BJP's politics in Assam. This is why, long before the Supreme Court's 2015 directive on implementing the NRC in Assam, Narendra Modi's primary political message while campaigning there in 2014 was on illegal migration. 'It is the need of the hour to stop the influx and we take this as our responsibility,' he said at an election rally in Gogamukh. 'After May 16 [when the election result comes